



The Gentle Starter Guide to Locs

A softer way to start your loc journey

Clear, caring guidance for women and girls who
want thriving locs without the confusion, pressure,
or perfectionism.

• HONEST GUIDANCE

• NO SHAME

• REAL-LIFE CARE



grow, glow & THRIVE

Document your journey. Be patient with yourself and your hair.
Your locs will evolve — one gentle step at a time.

Disclaimer



Everyone's hair is unique. Texture, density, porosity, lifestyle, and care all influence how locs form and mature. This guide offers general, practical guidance. Always follow the specific recommendations of your locician for your hair.

Understanding Locs

Locs form when hair is sectioned and left to mat and lock over time. The process moves through stages (starter/baby, budding, teenage, mature).

Full maturity often takes 6–18 months or longer depending on method, texture, and maintenance. Patience and consistency matter more than speed.

Complete the pre-start checklist (download the pre-starter checklist) before installation day.



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Before You Start

Common starting methods

Choose based on your hair texture, desired size/thickness, lifestyle, and how neat or organic you want the early stages to look..

Interlocking

The end of the section or loc is pulled through the root in a rotating pattern (often 2-, 3-, or 4-point). Creates a secure hold at the base.

Notes: Installation can take longer. Roots tend to stay secure through washing and activity. Suitable for small or medium sizing. (Sisterlocks is a specific trademarked interlocking system for micro locs that requires a certified consultant.)

Two-strand twists

Sections are divided into two strands and twisted together, then left to mature.

Notes: Gives fullness and volume early. The twist pattern can remain visible for about 6–12 months (sometimes longer). More prone to loosening, especially on softer or looser curl patterns. Not always the first choice for very soft textures.





Braiding / Plaiting.

Sections are braided and left to form locs.

Notes: The braid pattern often stays visible for a long time (sometimes 12–18 months or more). Holds relatively well but produces a different early appearance.

Palm rolling.

More commonly a maintenance technique (rolling the loc between the palms to smooth and encourage locking). It can support other starting methods rather than serve as the primary start.

Crochet / Instant Locs Method

Sections are usually first twisted, backcombed, or prepared, then a crochet hook is used to pull and interweave strands of hair into themselves repeatedly.

Notes: Creates locs that look more mature or “instant” from the start (or accelerate locking significantly). Often used when combining methods (with interlocking or after twists).

What method suits you?

Discuss this in consultation. Factors to consider include your hair texture and density, preferred loc size, how often you wash/sweat/swim, your tolerance for early frizz or pattern visibility, and maintenance preference.





Consultation, choosing your method & preparing for installation

- Book a consultation to assess your hair, discuss goals, and select method and size.

Prep before installation day

- Wash thoroughly. Blow-dry if you normally use heat (follow your loctician's instructions).
- No oils, creams, or leave-in conditioners.
- Get a trim if you haven't had one in 1-2 months — locs take on the shape and length of your current hair.
- If your hair is coloured or chemically treated, schedule at least one deep conditioning appointment beforehand.





Aftercare (The Early Weeks)

- Do not wash your hair until just before your second retightening (day before or same day).

Soft/loose curl patterns may need to wait until the third retie — follow your loctician's guidance exactly.

- When you do wash, use the braid-and-band method: section the hair, braid, and secure the ends with rubber bands. Use the same approach for swimming or any activity that regularly gets your hair wet.
- Avoid oils, creams, or lotions on your new locs. If needed, a very light oil can be applied directly to the scalp only. Rose water is generally all you need for moisturising.
- For itching or dryness on the scalp: Use rose water on the scalp and hair, or the recommended products (anti-itch scalp spray, Root Relief, or Dry Co-Wash spray). Apply these directly to the scalp only, not the locs. Microlocs are lightweight and should stay as product-free as possible.
- Pain in the first few days is common — simple over-the-counter pain relief is fine if needed.
- Bedtime protection: A satin bonnet or silk pillowcase helps prevent slippage and keeps lint out. If you tend to sweat on your scalp, mat your hair into two cornrows before sleeping as an alternative.
- Gently finger-comb through your locs and along your grid pattern a couple of times a week maximum. This helps prevent locs from joining. Be careful not to catch your nails.

Note to self

Your locs may look scalpy, scanty, or thin at the beginning. They typically thicken and fill in over time. Patience is essential right now.





Stages of Locs & What to Expect

Starter / Baby stage

Locs are new, may unravel easily, and look sparse.

Budding

Early matting begins.

Teenage stage

Locs can look messy, frizzy, or uneven as they expand and lock. This is temporary.

Mature stage

Locs become denser, more uniform, and lower-maintenance.

Document your journey with photos from time to time — the progress is encouraging and you may inspire someone else.

Questions to ask my locician at my next appointment

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Common Things That Can Happen

Itching

This is normal as the scalp adjusts or becomes dry. Use the recommended products.

Edges or nape loosening / unravelling

Common early on and usually fixed at retie appointments.

Slippage (gaps or holes)

Can occur occasionally, often linked to humidity or water exposure. Also changes in retie techniques. More common on softer curl patterns. Your stylist will assess and correct during reties. Speak up about any concerns.

Growth changes

Many people notice changes such as shrinkage at the baby or budding stage. Then quicker growth during the loc journey. It's likely because you're retaining length. Enjoy every stage.

Other possible experiences include temporary frizz, mild thinning at roots if tension is high, or product buildup if non-residue-free products are used. Address these early with your locician.

Lifestyle Considerations

Protect your locs during exercise, swimming, and sleep. Avoid heavy products. Be mindful of professional or social settings during the early "ugly" stages — they pass. Consistency with appointments and gentle care supports healthy results long-term.

Longer-Term Care Snapshot

Once past the first few months, washing frequency usually settles into more frequent weeks (every 3 weeks or as advised).

Maintenance (retwist, interlocking, or palm rolling of new growth) is typically every 4–8 weeks depending on method and growth rate.

Keep products minimal and residue-free. Continue scalp care and nighttime protection.





Enjoy the journey

Take it one step at a time with gentle, consistent care and regular appointments. Your locs will evolve — document the process and be patient with yourself and your hair.

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